

DAY OF DELIVERANCE

Aiden Markram's masterclass and Kagiso Rabada's firepower help South Africa break a long-standing hoodoo and deliver its **finest moment** in Tests.

Ayan Acharya

ayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

At Lord's, on a Saturday heavy with history, South African players did what generations before them could not.

They held their nerve. They closed the door. They won.

They are the new World Test Champions.

This was not just a Test match. This was a trial of identity. Of how a team, long weighed down by the memory of collapses, could finally write its own ending.

Australia, seasoned and sharp, was the favourite. It was the defending champion and had arrived with a pace attack as incisive as any in modern cricket. But asked to pull off what was eventually the joint second-highest successful fourth-innings chase at Lord's, South Africa didn't flinch. Aiden Markram and Temba Bavuma added 147 for the third wicket, steering their side to a historic win.

Markram brought up his eighth — and perhaps most significant — Test hundred. Bavuma, composed and assured despite a hamstring strain, reached a vital half-century.

It was a day of tension, but of a different kind. The collapse and chaos of the first innings gave way to calculation and control.

Tactically, Cummins may have erred on the third afternoon. As Markram and Bavuma settled into their partnership, Australia's field placements grew increasingly defensive. With the field spread wide, the pair collected ones

